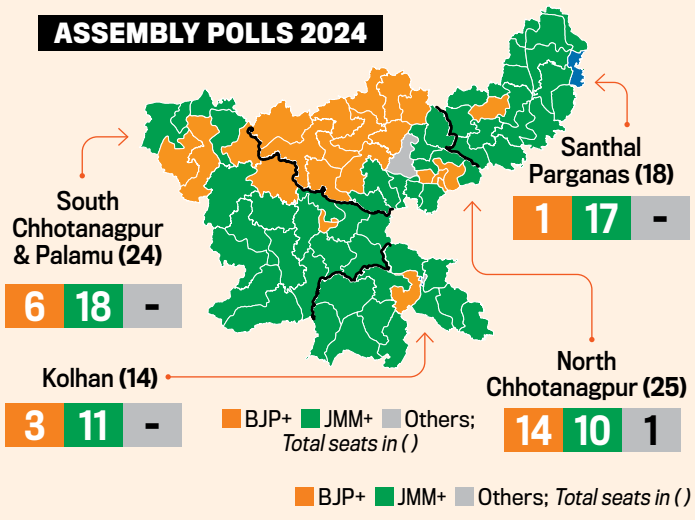


TAKING GOOD AIM Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren campaigning at Silli assembly constituency, Nov. 20

SOMNATH SEN

JMM SPREADS IT EVENLY

Barring the North Chhotanagpur region, where the BJP-led NDA did well, the JMM and allies swept all areas



pointed Champai defected to the BJP a month later.

Fast forward to November 23, and the assembly results have affirmed Soren as Jharkhand's most popular leader—the first CM ever to return to power. The verdict was emphatic—the JMM-led INDIA bloc swept 56 out of 81 assembly seats, leaving the BJP-led NDA struggling with a mere 24. The JMM alone bagged 34 seats—its best-ever performance. Its allies bolstered the win: the Congress claimed 16 seats, the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) added four, and the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation held up two. For the NDA, the results were sobering. The BJP managed 21 seats; while its partners—the All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU), Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), and Janata Dal (United)—could muster just one apiece.

Hemant Checkmates BJP

To outmanoeuvre the BJP, Soren had to broad-base his tactics. Adivasi pride would only hold up the heartland; if anything, it could sharpen the tribal-vs-others divide and deepen the anti-incumbency